

*Small Group Bible Study Series*

# Galatians 3:1–5

## *Under a Spell*

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| ① TEXT     | ② DEVOTIONAL      | ③ COMMENTARY | ④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE |
|------------|-------------------|--------------|--------------------|
| Foundation | Personal Prep     | Teacher Prep | Group Meeting      |
| Everyone   | All group members | Leader       | Small group        |

⑤ *Application closes each study and draws from all sections above.*

## ① THE BIBLICAL TEXT

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Foundation · Everyone · NKJV

### **Galatians 3:1–5**

**1** *O foolish Galatians! Who has bewitched you that you should not obey the truth, before whose eyes Jesus Christ was clearly portrayed among you as crucified?*

**2** *This only I want to learn from you: Did you receive the Spirit by the works of the law, or by the hearing of faith?*

**3** *Are you so foolish? Having begun in the Spirit, are you now being made perfect by the flesh?*

**4** *Have you suffered so many things in vain—if indeed it was in vain?*

**5** *Therefore He who supplies the Spirit to you and works miracles among you, does He do it by the works of the law, or by the hearing of faith?*

## ② DEVOTIONAL

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*Personal preparation · All group members*

**“Grace is not grace if something is added to it.”**

Before you ever kept a single command, Christ was already placarded before your eyes — preached to you, pictured in your baptism, remembered every time you came to His table. Grace reached the Galatians first, before the law ever had a claim on them, and it reached you the same way. That's not just history; it's the ground you are still standing on.

The same grace that saved you is the grace that keeps you. Paul asks the Galatians whether they were perfected by the Spirit or by the flesh, and the answer is obvious: you are already perfect in Christ, accepted because of what He has done, not because of what you do. Your fellowship with God today doesn't need to be earned back — only enjoyed.

Watch for it this week: is God working in your life by the hearing of faith — simple trust in what He has already promised — or are you quietly slipping back toward “do this and live”? Grace that began the work is still the grace that supplies the Spirit and works in you today.

### **Reflect**

- Where this week have you caught yourself trying to add works to grace, even in small ways?
- What difference does it make to know your acceptance before God is already settled, not something you're still earning?
- Who in your life needs to hear that grace, not law, is what actually saves and keeps?

*Rest today in the grace that found you first.*

### ③ COMMENTARY

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Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

**PROPOSITION:** Grace, not law, both received the Galatians into Christ and sustains them in Christ — so Paul's five questions expose the utter folly of turning from grace to law at every stage of the Christian life: its precedence, procedure, perfection, persecution, and promotion.

#### I. The Question about the Precedence of Christianity — 3:1

A long time ago I read — or maybe heard the illustration somewhere — about a boy in Europe, in maybe the early 1900s. His parents wanted their son, who was about fifteen or sixteen, to come to America and enjoy the things that are here and make something of himself. They couldn't afford the trip, but they had relatives here, and one of the relatives sent the passage so he could come. His mother packed him his food — we're talking about probably a thirty-day trip — cheese, a big package of it, and a big supply of crackers, cookies, and bread, whatever else he had. Cheese and crackers. Every time lunchtime or dinnertime came, he broke off a piece of cheese and ate some crackers. That was his dinner. He was doing fine.

Then he got to America, and the family met him and asked, “How was your trip?” He said, “My trip was fine, but I just don't want to see any more cheese and crackers for a long while.” They said, “Cheese and crackers? What? They fed you cheese and crackers?” “Oh, no — my mom packed it, and I ate that all the way over.” “Don't you know your passage included all the food you could eat?”

A lot of Christians are like that. We have been blessed with all the spiritual blessings in the heavens in Christ, and some people are eating cheese and crackers. Some are living by the law and not by grace. All the plenteousness of grace is there before them, and they follow the law instead.

Paul was amazed — he shows it here in chapter 3 — at the way these Galatians were now behaving, because of how graciously they had received him when he was with them. In Galatians 4:13–15 he writes:

*“You know that because of physical infirmity I preached the gospel to you at the first. And my trial which was in my flesh you did not despise or reject, but you received me as an angel of God, even as Christ Jesus. What then was the blessing you enjoyed? For I bear you witness that, if possible, you would have plucked out your own eyes and given them to me.” (Galatians 4:13–15)*

They received him as an angel of God — even as Jesus Christ. They would have plucked out their own eyes and given them to Paul. Ever been treated like that? That's amazing — that was his perception of how graciously they had greeted him. It reminds me of visiting one of my Greek students this past summer. I had never met him before; I only knew him from the phone, helping him with his Greek questions. When we got there and called to say we were stopping by, he said, “Oh, brother, you're going to come to my house? It's so wonderful — thank you for coming.” Several times over the two days we stayed, he kept saying, “Brother, I can't believe

you've come to my house to stay. Thank you so much for coming." I thought, who, me? But that's the way it was — and that's the way Paul was treated by the Galatians. (This plucking-out-the-eyes language, by the way, is where some interpreters go to argue that Paul's thorn in the flesh was his eyesight — that may or may not be so; just a side note.)

That was amazing — the way they had treated him. But what is more amazing is that they had turned away from the teaching of the grace gospel he had taught them. They loved him, they treated him well, they listened to him and believed the gospel — and now they had turned away from it. Paul expresses his horror in Galatians 1:6:

*"I marvel that you are turning away so soon from Him who called you in the grace of Christ, to a different gospel." (Galatians 1:6)*

They had turned away —

*from Mount Calvary to Mount Sinai  
from liberty to bondage  
from Sonship to servant-hood  
from faith to works  
from Christ to Ceremonies.*

Now, if you want to see Paul's outline for this passage — and Paul wrote with an outline, like everybody else does — you can see it by following the question marks in these five verses, chapter 3, verses 1 through 5. Every question mark marks the end of one point: five points here about their turning aside. He asks about:

*the Precedence of Christianity  
the Procedure of Christianity  
the Perfection of Christianity  
the Persecution of Christianity  
the Promotion of Christianity.*

Paul usually expresses some form of thanks for the people he's writing to — in the personal epistles, Timothy, Titus, Philemon, he calls them dear brothers, tells them he loves them, that he remembers them in prayer. That's not how he greets the Galatians. Here it's "O foolish Galatians." That signals the surprise, the perplexity, and the indignation running through the whole letter. It seems impossible to him that they have turned from the grace he taught to the legalizing bondage of the Judaizers.

### **3:1 — "O foolish Galatians..."**

He calls them ἄνοητοι — foolish, unintelligent. He doesn't mean they are demented; they are simply not using the sense God gave them. (I remember, way back in my childhood, if you did something stupid somebody would say, "You don't have the sense God gave a goose." They weren't using the sense God gave them.)

Then he asks, "Who has bewitched you?" — ἐβάσκανεν — who put a hex on you, cast a spell on you? He is not seriously thinking they have been hexed; this is hyperbole, exaggeration for effect, meant to underscore the sheer stupidity of their actions. Bluntly, Paul is asking, "Have you lost your mind?" Today we might say, "What were you thinking?"

The word “who” is singular. If that has any significance, it may point to the one who stands behind all deception — Satan. Jesus said of him:

*“You are of your father the devil, and the desires of your father you want to do. He was a murderer from the beginning, and does not stand in the truth, because there is no truth in him. When he speaks a lie, he speaks from his own resources, for he is a liar and the father of it.” (John 8:44)*

And Peter warns:

*“Be sober, be vigilant; because your adversary the devil walks about like a roaring lion, seeking whom he may devour.” (1 Peter 5:8)*

Think about that. I see these pictures where people are going into places and the lion jumps up, or whatever that is — I couldn't do that. And yet there is a roaring lion after me all the time, and after you as well. He wants to devour you, just like Satan is going to try to do.

These Galatians turned to the Law in spite of the fact that Jesus had been portrayed — placarded — among them: through Paul's preaching, through their baptism, and through the Lord's Supper.

Through Paul's preaching:

*“and by Him everyone who believes is justified from all things from which you could not be justified by the law of Moses.” (Acts 13:39)*

Christ on the cross took away their sin and did everything that needed to be done — and that could not happen by the law of Moses.

Through their baptism — believers in that day were baptized right away:

*“Or do you not know that as many of us as were baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into His death?” (Romans 6:3)*

That is Spirit baptism, of course, but water baptism pictures it — buried with Him in baptism, raised to walk in newness of life. When they were baptized, Christ was placarded before them; they had redemption through Him.

Through the Lord's Supper, which they observed regularly:

*“This is My body which is given for you . . . This is My blood of the new covenant, which is shed for many for the remission of sins.” (Matthew 26:26, 28)*

The blood of the new covenant — the grace covenant, not the old covenant, not the law.

In their experience, grace had preceded the law — for the Gentiles Paul preached to, and for the Jews as well, grace had preceded their coming to Christianity. Grace is not grace if something is added to it.

## II. The Question about the Procedure of Christianity — 3:2

*"This only I want to learn from you: Did you receive the Spirit by the works of the law, or by the hearing of faith?" (Galatians 3:2)*

Only one question — if Paul could get that one answer, he wouldn't need anything else.

These Galatians were already saved, and they had received the Holy Spirit. Salvation and the reception of the Spirit are not two separate events; they are simultaneous, though not synonymous — they happen at the same moment. (There are some thirty-three things that happen to a person the moment he believes, according to Chafer's Systematic Theology — a whole list, if you'd like it.) One of them is receiving the Holy Spirit, and anyone who does not have the Holy Spirit is not part of the body of Christ:

*"For by one Spirit we were all baptized into one body — whether Jews or Greeks, whether slaves or free — and have all been made to drink into one Spirit." (1 Corinthians 12:13)*

And whoever does not have the Spirit does not belong to Christ:

*"But you are not in the flesh but in the Spirit, if indeed the Spirit of God dwells in you. Now if anyone does not have the Spirit of Christ, he is not His." (Romans 8:9)*

The difference is:

- The law says "Do" — Grace says "Done."
- The law says "Try" — Grace says "Trust."
- The law says "Behave" — Grace says "Believe."
- The law points to the commandment — Grace points to Christ.
- The weakness of the Law is the flesh — the wonder of Grace is the Holy Spirit.
- The Law requires man's achievement — Grace rests on Christ's achievement.

So Paul is asking about the procedure of their salvation: were you saved by doing good works, or by the hearing of faith? The answer has to be by the hearing of faith — that is, by grace.

So that's the precedence, the procedure — but now the perfection of Christianity.

### III. The Question about the Perfection of Christianity — 3:3

*"Are you so foolish? Having begun in the Spirit, are you now being made perfect by the flesh?" (Galatians 3:3)*

J. B. Phillips paraphrases the verse: "Surely you can't be so idiotic as to think that a man begins his spiritual life in the Spirit and then completes it by reverting to outward observances."

Hebrews explains the concept well:

*"For by one offering He has perfected forever those who are being sanctified." (Hebrews 10:14)*

The one who believes has been perfected forever — how? By one sacrifice. He died in your place.

I had the chance to speak with a lot of people on vacation — I love just passing out tracts. I found one fellow — we had stopped, had gone into a store — and this man came up to me, and about everything he said was, “Thank you, Father, thank you, Father.” I asked him, “Are you a believer?” “Yeah.” “What do you believe?” He wasn’t too sure, so I gave him a version of Kennedy’s Evangelism Explosion question: “Suppose you came to heaven and they asked you, why should I let you in?” He named several things. I said, “No — what you need to say is, Jesus Christ paid for my sins; my sins are paid for; I’m no longer a sinner; I’m able to step into your heaven because my sin has been paid for.” He liked that — “Oh, thank you, Father.” But that is exactly what this verse is saying: by one sacrifice, we are completed, accepted by God.

There’s a hymn — I don’t think it’s in our hymnal — that goes, “God sees my Savior, and then He sees me, in the Beloved, accepted and free.”

Our perfection before God is settled forever by that one sacrifice of Christ. Nothing can change that position before God — that is our perfection. My practice is not on the same level as my perfection. I am perfect before God, I stand before Him perfect in Christ, and I have a relationship with Him because of that perfection. But my fellowship with Him depends on how I am being sanctified — that is, on bringing my practice up to the level of my perfection, which is what I ought to be striving to do all the time. My practice — what I do — is not what causes God to accept me. I am already accepted; I can be no more accepted by doing anything, even the law. God does not look at what I do; He looks at what Christ has done. He does not simply pay the down payment on the cross and then leave us to keep up the payments the rest of our lives, hoping to get to heaven — that is not it.

Paul’s question, then, is a logical one: are you going to complete the work Christ has already completed? Suppose a concert pianist somehow climbed inside me, and I sat down and played a fantastic piece of music. That is the way it is with these Galatians. First, the work has already been completed. Second, it is a divine work they cannot perform themselves. Now imagine, after the pianist inside me has played the whole piece to applause, I said to him, “Get out of my way — I’ll finish this myself.” Wouldn’t that be silly? That is what happens in our salvation: Christ in us brings us to perfection, and then we say, “Okay, now get out of the way — I’ll do the rest myself, I’ll add some works of the law, I’ll complete what you started.”

Paul is right — they are foolish. First, the work had already been completed. Second, it is a divine work, and they cannot do it anyway. So that’s the precedence, the procedure, the perfection. Now, the persecution.

#### IV. The Question about the Persecution of Christianity — 3:4

| *“Have you suffered so many things in vain—if indeed it was in vain?” (Galatians 3:4)*

When they believed, they suffered much persecution. Luke records that Paul had warned the Galatians of this before he returned to Antioch in Syria after the first missionary journey:

| *“And when they had preached the gospel to that city and made many disciples, they returned to Lystra, Iconium, and Antioch [Pisidia — the cities of Galatia], strengthening the souls of the disciples, exhorting them to continue in the faith, and saying, “We must through many tribulations enter the kingdom of God.”” (Acts 14:21–22)*

The Jewish Christians especially suffered persecution from the other Jews in the synagogue and in the Jewish community, but it was not limited to the Jews — both Jew and Gentile were in that church, and the Gentiles preached and witnessed to all the residents of the city, Jews included, and probably even ran afoul of the Roman authorities for it. There was enough persecution to go around.

Paul reminds them that if they go back to Judaism, all of that suffering will have been in vain. Then he adds, “if indeed it was in vain” — as if to say, “It would be in vain if you go back to the Law — but I don’t think you will.” It may be a note of encouragement: he’s not entirely certain the report he’s heard is true of them, or that it will hold in their case. He may have been hoping that this very letter would turn them around — that was certainly his purpose in writing it. So there’s the precedence, the procedure, the perfection, the persecution — and now the promotion: another argument for the grace gospel.

## V. The Question about the Promotion of Christianity — 3:5

“Therefore He who supplies the Spirit to you and works miracles among you, does He do it by the works of the law, or by the hearing of faith?” **(Galatians 3:5)**

What was there in Paul’s ministry that attested to the truth of the gospel? It was the miracles. In Lystra the people wanted to offer sacrifices to Paul and Barnabas, calling them gods — and there is one miracle in particular Paul has in mind:

“And in Lystra a certain man without strength in his feet was sitting, a cripple from his mother’s womb, who had never walked. This man heard Paul speaking. Paul, observing him intently and seeing that he had faith to be healed, said . . .” **(Acts 14:8–9)**

What did Paul say?

- Keep the commandments —
- Have no other gods before God,
- Don’t take the Lord’s name in vain,
- Don’t make any graven images,
- Remember the Sabbath day,
- Honor your father and mother,
- Don’t steal, lie, commit adultery, or covet anything that belongs to your neighbor?

None of the above.

“He said with a loud voice, “Stand up straight on your feet!” And he leaped and walked.” **(Acts 14:10)**

No law there — just the grace of God to a poor, undeserving cripple. That is the way your salvation came: totally by grace, through faith, to undeserving, unworthy sinners.

No — are you trying to keep the law? I know you didn’t come here yesterday to church — I was here, you weren’t — but are you doing certain things, telling yourself, “We’ve got to do this, we can’t do that,” as if that’s what perfects you? You can’t do it. In the first place, you cannot keep

the law; and if you could keep it, God wouldn't accept it on that basis. Give up on the law. There's an old song that goes:

*““Do this and live,” the law demands, and gives me neither feet nor hands. A better word the gospel brings: it bids me fly and gives me wings.”*

God help us to accept the wings God gives, to do the things of God, and to give Him all the glory.

*Lord, thank You.*

## ④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

### Greek Word Study

| Verse | Greek Word / English                            | Strong's # / Translit. / Form                                          | Definition & Significance                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|-------|-------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| v.1   | <b>ἀνόητοι</b><br><i>foolish</i>                | G453<br><i>anoētoi</i><br>Voc. Pl. Masc. Adj.                          | STR: “without understanding, senseless.” THAY: not demented but failing to use given moral sense. Significance: Paul's address sets the letter's tone — indignant surprise, not gentle correction.                                 |
| v.1   | <b>ἐβάσκανεν</b><br><i>has bewitched</i>        | G940<br><i>ebaskanen</i><br>Aor. Act. Ind. 3rd Sg.                     | STR/MRV: lit. “to cast an evil eye upon, to charm.” ATR: aorist views the bewitching as a completed act. Significance: hyperbole — Paul isn't alleging literal sorcery but exposing how irrational their defection is.             |
| v.1   | <b>προεγράφη</b><br><i>clearly portrayed</i>    | G4270<br><i>proographē</i><br>Aor. Pass. Ind. 3rd Sg.                  | MRV: classical sense “posted up publicly,” as an official notice or placard. Significance: matches the sermon's “placarded” image — Christ crucified was publicly displayed before them by preaching, baptism, and the Table.      |
| v.1   | <b>ἐσταυρωμένος</b><br><i>crucified</i>         | G4717<br><i>estaurōmenos</i><br>Perf. Pass. Ptc. Nom. Sg. Masc.        | ATR: the perfect tense marks a completed act with abiding results — Christ stands permanently in the crucified position before their eyes. Significance: the cross is not a fading memory but a settled, present reality.          |
| v.2   | <b>πνεῦμα</b><br><i>the Spirit</i>              | G4151<br><i>pneuma</i><br>Acc. Sg. Neut.                               | STR/THAY: the Holy Spirit, received at the moment of faith. LXX: carries forward OT expectation of the Spirit poured out (Joel 2:28). Significance: reception of the Spirit is Paul's proof-text for how salvation actually works. |
| v.2   | <b>ἔργων νόμου</b><br><i>works of the law</i>   | G2041 / G3551<br><i>ergōn nomou</i><br>Gen. Pl. Neut. / Gen. Sg. Masc. | THAY: deeds done in obedience to the Mosaic code. VINE: contrasted throughout Galatians with faith as the ground of acceptance. Significance: names the very thing the Galatians were tempted to add to grace.                     |
| v.2   | <b>ἀκοῆς πίστεως</b><br><i>hearing of faith</i> | G189 / G4102<br><i>akoēs pisteōs</i><br>Gen. Sg. Fem. / Gen. Sg. Fem.  | THAY: ἀκοή is the message heard, or the act of hearing. ATR: genitive of source — faith arising from what is heard. Significance: salvation and the Spirit both come by believing a report, not performing a code.                 |
| v.3   | <b>ἐπιτελεῖσθε</b><br><i>being made perfect</i> | G2005<br><i>epiteleisthe</i><br>Pres. Mid./Pass. Ind. 2nd Pl.          | STR/VINE: “to bring to completion, finish.” MRV: present tense pictures an ongoing (attempted) process. Significance: the irony Paul presses — trying to finish by the flesh what only the Spirit began.                           |
| v.3   | <b>σαρκί</b><br><i>the flesh</i>                | G4561<br><i>sarki</i><br>Dat. Sg. Fem.                                 | STR/THAY: unregenerate human effort/nature, opposed to Spirit. Significance: names the power source the Galatians substituted for the Spirit — self-effort in place of grace.                                                      |

| Verse | Greek Word / English                      | Strong's # / Translit. / Form                                               | Definition & Significance                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-------|-------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| v.4   | ἐπάθετε<br><i>have you suffered</i>       | G3958<br><i>epathete</i><br>Aor. Act. Ind. 2nd Pl.                          | STR: to experience, undergo, especially hardship. Significance: their past suffering for the gospel is Paul's evidence that they once knew, and stood for, the true gospel.                                  |
| v.4   | εἰκῇ<br><i>in vain</i>                    | G1500<br><i>eikē</i><br>Adverb                                              | STR/MRV: "without cause, to no purpose, fruitlessly." Significance: returning to the law would retroactively empty their suffering of any meaning.                                                           |
| v.5   | ἐπιχορηγῶν<br><i>who supplies</i>         | G2023<br><i>epichorēgōn</i><br>Pres. Act. Ptc. Nom. Sg. Masc.               | MRV: classical root meaning "to fund a chorus at one's own expense" — lavish, ongoing provision. Significance: God's supply of the Spirit is not a one-time grant but a continuous, generous furnishing.     |
| v.5   | ἐνεργῶν δυνάμεις<br><i>works miracles</i> | G1754 / G1411<br><i>energōn dynameis</i><br>Pres. Act. Ptc. / Acc. Pl. Fem. | STR: ἐνεργέω, to be operative, effectual; δυνάμις, works of power. Significance: the same faith-channel that brought salvation is the channel through which God's ongoing power is still at work among them. |

Grammar Key: Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. | Verb Mood: Ind. · Imp. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass.

## Study Questions

### Part 1 — From the Commentary

| Paul's Question       | What It Exposes                                                                                            |
|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The Precedence (3:1)  | Grace, pictured in preaching, baptism, and the Table, reached them before any law-keeping could.           |
| The Procedure (3:2)   | They received the Spirit by the hearing of faith, not by works of the law.                                 |
| The Perfection (3:3)  | Begun by the Spirit, a believer cannot be completed by the flesh — Christ's one offering perfects forever. |
| The Persecution (3:4) | Turning back to the law would make their suffering for the gospel meaningless.                             |
| The Promotion (3:5)   | The Spirit's ongoing work and miracles among them came by faith, not law-keeping.                          |

### Part 2 — Study Questions

#### 1. According to Galatians 4:13–15, how did the Galatians originally treat Paul, and why does that make their present turning away so startling?

Leader answer: They received him as an angel of God — even as Christ Jesus — and would have given him their own eyes. Their present coldness toward grace is jarring precisely because their earlier love for Paul, and for the gospel he preached, had been so warm.

**2. What does it mean that receiving the Spirit and being saved are simultaneous but not synonymous?**

Leader answer: They happen at the same moment of faith, but they are two distinct realities — salvation is God's declaration of righteousness; receiving the Spirit is God's gift of His presence. Both come by the hearing of faith, not by works of the law.

**3. Explain, in your own words, the difference between your perfection and your practice (3:3).**

Leader answer: Perfection is your settled standing before God, secured forever by Christ's one sacrifice (Hebrews 10:14) — it cannot be added to or improved. Practice is your daily walk, brought along by sanctification. Practice never causes God to accept you; it flows from being already accepted.

**4. Why would going back to the law make the Galatians' past suffering “in vain” (3:4)?**

Leader answer: They had suffered persecution specifically for believing and preaching the grace gospel. If they abandoned that gospel for law-keeping, the very thing they suffered for would no longer be the thing they stood on — emptying that suffering of its purpose.

**5. What did Paul actually say to the lame man in Lystra (Acts 14:8–10), and what does that reveal about the source of the “miracles” in Galatians 3:5?**

Leader answer: He did not recite the law; he simply said, “Stand up straight on your feet!” and the man leaped and walked. The miracle came by faith, with no law involved — showing that the same grace-by-faith principle that saves also powers God's ongoing work among His people.

**Part 3 — Passage Summary**

| Verse | Key Question | One-Line Answer                                            |
|-------|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| v.1   | Precedence   | Christ was already placarded before them by grace.         |
| v.2   | Procedure    | The Spirit came by hearing of faith, not by works.         |
| v.3   | Perfection   | What began in the Spirit cannot be perfected by the flesh. |
| v.4   | Persecution  | Returning to law would make past suffering pointless.      |
| v.5   | Promotion    | Ongoing power comes the same way salvation did — by faith. |

## ⑤ APPLICATION

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*Closes the study · Personal and corporate*

### 1. Rest in a Finished Placard

**Scripture anchor:** Galatians 3:1; Acts 13:39

**Source:** *Commentary, The Precedence of Christianity*

Christ was placarded before the Galatians — preached, pictured in baptism, remembered at the Table — before they ever attempted to keep a single command. The same is true of you: grace reached you first, and nothing you do adds to what was already displayed and finished at the cross.

**Reflection:** Where do you find yourself trying to add something — effort, performance, guilt — to a gift that was already complete?

**Practical Step:** Before your first request in prayer this week, spend one minute simply thanking God for what is already finished at the cross.

### 2. Trade Trying for Trusting

**Scripture anchor:** Galatians 3:2, 5

**Source:** *Commentary, The Procedure and Promotion of Christianity*

The law says “Do”; grace says “Done.” The law says “Try”; grace says “Trust.” Both the Galatians’ salvation and God’s ongoing work of power among them came the same way — by the hearing of faith, not by works of the law.

**Reflection:** Name one area of your life right now where you have been “trying” instead of “trusting.”

**Practical Step:** Tell God out loud today, specifically, that you are trusting Him rather than trying to earn the outcome yourself.

### 3. Let Your Practice Catch Up to Your Perfection

**Scripture anchor:** Galatians 3:3; Hebrews 10:14

**Source:** *Commentary, The Perfection of Christianity*

You are already perfected forever by Christ’s one offering — that standing cannot be improved. Sanctification is simply bringing your daily practice up to the level of a perfection you already possess, not a project to earn it.

**Reflection:** How would today look different if you approached obedience as gratitude flowing from acceptance, rather than as a bid for acceptance?

**Practical Step:** Pick one specific habit this week and practice it as a response to being accepted, not as an attempt to become accepted.

### 4. Don't Let Suffering Talk You Into Retreat

**Scripture anchor:** Galatians 3:4

**Source:** *Commentary, The Persecution of Christianity*

The Galatians had suffered real persecution for the grace gospel. Paul warns that retreating into law-keeping would make that suffering meaningless. Hardship for standing on grace is never a signal to abandon it.

**Reflection:** Has difficulty or opposition ever tempted you to quietly trade grace for a safer, more rule-bound faith?

**Practical Step:** If you are facing pushback for living by grace this week, ask one trusted believer to pray with you rather than pulling back.

*End of Study · Galatians 3:1–5*